

SAMĀDHI WATER REPENTANCE

SCROLL ONE PRACTICE GUIDE

An explained English guide to the opening scroll

origin • refuge • afflictions • vows • wisdom

Prepared by Daniel Franjkovic

daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

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Open the project

Scroll One Practice Companion

An explained English guide to the opening scroll

Prepared by
Daniel Franjkovic
daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

Source edition
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English translation by Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong
Covers Scroll One

Further glossary
www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

This independent educational companion explains the official English liturgy without reproducing it. The source PDFs remain copyrighted by Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple and are linked in the references.

Designed for clear A4 printing. Complete collection edition, August 2026.

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PDF bookmarks provide direct navigation to every major section.



Scroll One

What each part is doing and why

An explained companion to Scroll One

For other Buddhist terms, visit the Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center Glossary.

This companion explains the English text of the 2022 Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple edition. It does not reproduce or replace the liturgy. Keep the official Scroll One PDF beside this guide when reading or chanting.

How to use this guide

Read “The Buddhist world behind the words” first if the terms karma, Pure Land, emptiness or bodhisattva are new. Then use the page-by-page guide below while following the source.

Source-page references use the PDF page number. The smaller printed number inside the liturgy starts later and is different.

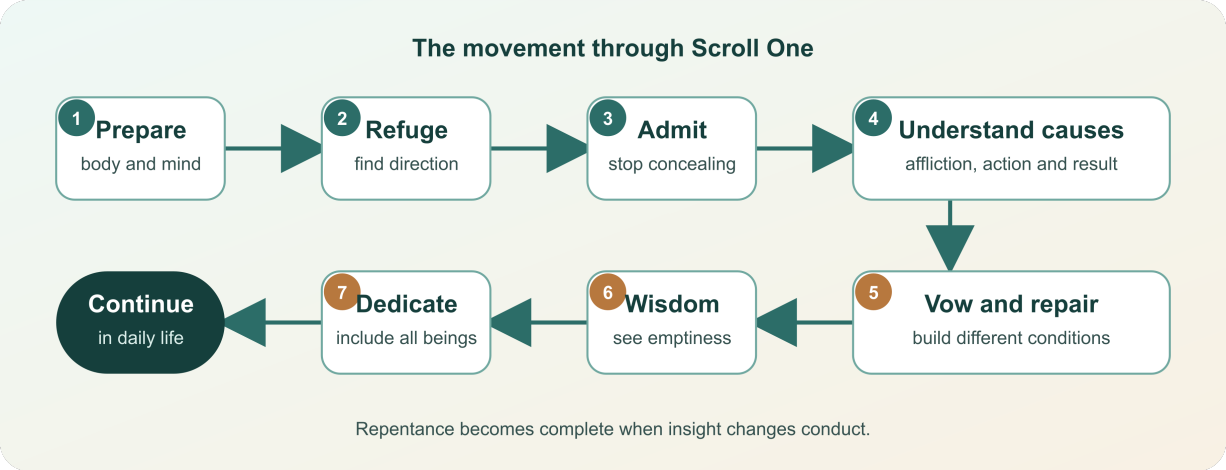
> In simple terms The practice asks: What has caused harm? Can I admit it without hiding? What conditions fed it? What will I do differently? How can the benefit of that change include others?

What the title means

- Kindness and compassion name the attitude towards oneself and all beings.
- Samādhi is a collected, steady mind that is not swept away by reactions.
- Water symbolises cleansing and refers to the spring in the traditional Wuda story.
- Repentance means acknowledging harm and reforming future conduct.

- Liturgy means a structured communal service of chant, movement, reflection and dedication.

The practice at a glance



The ritual is not simply a long confession. It moves from reverence and attention to honest acknowledgement, analysis of causes, vows, wisdom and dedication.

Guide to Scroll One

1. Imperial Preface for Water Repentance

Source pages 3 to 4

What is happening?

A Ming-period imperial preface explains the title and recommends the practice. It defines samādhi as a mind that does not indulge or chase sensation, then compares repentance with washing a body, garment or vessel.

Why is it here?

The preface gives the reader a moral frame before the chanting begins: actions have effects, the mind is central, and sincere reform can change the conditions that support suffering.

What does it mean?

“Samādhi water” is both story and metaphor. The water cleanses because it is joined with collected awareness, truthfulness and change. The point is not that ordinary water magically deletes the past.

Beginner notes

- National Master was an honorific for a highly respected monastic teacher associated with the imperial court.
- Karmic enmity means hostility carried and reinforced through intentional actions, traditionally across lives.
- Trichiliocosm is an ancient Buddhist expression for an immensely vast world-system.
- The preface is dated 24 July 1416, much later than the traditional Tang setting of Wuda's story.

2. Preface of the Water Repentance

Source pages 4 to 5

What is happening?

The liturgy tells its traditional origin narrative. Wuda Zhixuan cares for a sick monk when others avoid him. Later, after receiving an imperial throne and becoming proud, Wuda develops a human-faced tumour. The tumour speaks as a former enemy. Honoured Kanaka directs Wuda to wash it with water from a spring, ending the feud.

Why is it here?

The story makes invisible patterns visible. Pride weakens vigilance. Kindness creates a future refuge. Retaliation persists until its causes are understood and released.

What does it mean?

The tumour represents unresolved harm that cannot be escaped by status, learning or denial. Wuda's healing is not only the removal of pain. It is reconciliation with a being presented as his enemy across lives.

> Historical note The Wuda account is the liturgy's traditional explanation. Modern scholarship finds the exact authorship uncertain and notes that versions of the attribution were questioned in medieval China. The guide treats the story as a sacred origin narrative, not verified medical history.

Beginner notes

- Kāmalā disease is an old medical term associated with jaundice and severe illness.
- Honoured Kanaka is the mysterious awakened helper in the narrative. The text does not give a historically verifiable biography.
- The story assumes rebirth and karmic continuity. It should not be used to blame an ill person for unknown past conduct.

3. Prostrations and the True Incense Praise

Source page 7

What is happening?

The assembly bows, prostrates three times and praises the “true incense” of ethical discipline and concentration.

Why is it done?

The body enters the practice before the main confession begins. Prostration softens pride, while incense makes intention visible through fragrance rising and spreading.

What does it mean?

The real offering is not smoke alone. Ethical conduct and a steady mind are the fragrance the practitioner is asked to cultivate.

> Look for this in a temple Three prostrations often express complete homage to the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha. Follow the officiant's pace if attending a service.

4. Retelling the Wuda story

Source pages 8 to 10

What is happening?

A formal verse retells the origin story in elevated ritual language. It moves from pride and karmic enmity through the journey to Kanaka and the cleansing water.

Why is it done?

Repetition changes the story from background information into contemplation. Practitioners are invited to recognise their own pride, grudges and hidden patterns.

Beginner notes

- Ten unwholesome deeds are killing, stealing, sexual misconduct; false, divisive, harsh and careless speech; greed, ill will and wrong views.
- Five degenerations describe a troubled age marked by decline in lifespan, beings, afflictions, views and the age itself.
- Nine grades of lotuses are traditional levels of rebirth in Amitābha's Pure Land.

5. Samantabhadra visualisation

Source pages 10 to 12

What is happening?

The assembly invokes Samantabhadra, then imagines the bodhisattva approaching on a white elephant amid light, flowers, music and countless awakened beings.

Why is it done?

Samantabhadra represents great vows expressed as conduct. The visualisation turns the imagination towards a world shaped by wisdom, beauty and purposeful action.

What does it mean?

The scene should not be read like a newspaper report. It is sacred imagery that trains perception. Light represents wisdom; flowers represent virtue and impermanence; the elephant represents calm strength; its six tusks are commonly linked with the six perfections.

The six perfections are generosity, ethical discipline, patience, diligent effort, meditation and wisdom.

> Why this matters Repentance is incomplete if it only looks backward. Samantabhadra asks what vow and practice will replace the harmful pattern.

6. Refuge and universal offering

Source pages 12 to 15

What is happening?

The assembly prostrates to the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha, kneels with incense and flowers, and imagines the offering multiplying throughout all worlds.

Why is it done?

Taking refuge establishes the direction of the practice. The universal offering expands generosity beyond the limits of what is physically present.

What does it mean?

The language in which every offering contains all offerings reflects the Flower Adornment vision of interdependence. A small sincere act can participate in a much wider field of benefit.

Beginner notes

- Ten directions means everywhere: the four main directions, four intermediate directions, above and below.
- Dharma realm means the whole field of beings and phenomena.

- Bodhi mind is the resolve to awaken for the benefit of all beings.
- Non-arising means insight that phenomena do not appear from an independent permanent essence.

7. Prayer of entering repentance

Source pages 15 to 18

What is happening?

The assembly formally enters the repentance sanctuary. Practitioners purify body, speech and mind, take refuge, confess and ask the awakened assembly to witness their sincerity.

Why is it done?

Ritual boundaries help the mind stop treating the words as ordinary reading. Kneeling, joined palms, flowers and incense support concentrated honesty.

What does it mean?

“Purifying the three karmas” means bringing bodily conduct, speech and intention into alignment. “Four forms of birth” and “six realms” place the confession within the traditional scope of all sentient life.

The Seven Ancient Buddhas then situate the practice in a lineage of awakening extending beyond one historical age.

8. Opening confession and Buddha-name litany

Source pages 19 to 23

What is happening?

The assembly admits disbelief, arrogance, neglect of family, intoxicant use, killing, sexual craving and other harmful conduct. It then invokes Buddhas, bodhisattvas and sacred assemblies.

Why is it done?

Naming patterns weakens concealment. Reciting awakened names provides a contrasting field of qualities: wisdom, compassion, strength, vows and liberation.

What does it mean?

The passage uses “we” and covers more wrongdoing than any one reader may have committed. Communal repentance is deliberately comprehensive. A practitioner can acknowledge the pattern without making a false personal confession.

> Reading responsibly Do not mechanically claim an action you did not commit. Attend to the forms of harm that genuinely apply, the social conditions that allow harm and the commitment to prevent it.

Beginner notes

- Field of merit means a person or community in relation to whom wholesome action bears abundant benefit, like a well-tended field bearing crops.
- Pratyekabuddha means one who awakens without teaching a dispensation to the world.
- Four fruitions and four progressions are four stages of early Buddhist awakening, each viewed as path and result.
- Devas and nāgas are non-human beings in traditional Buddhist cosmology.

9. The three obstructions

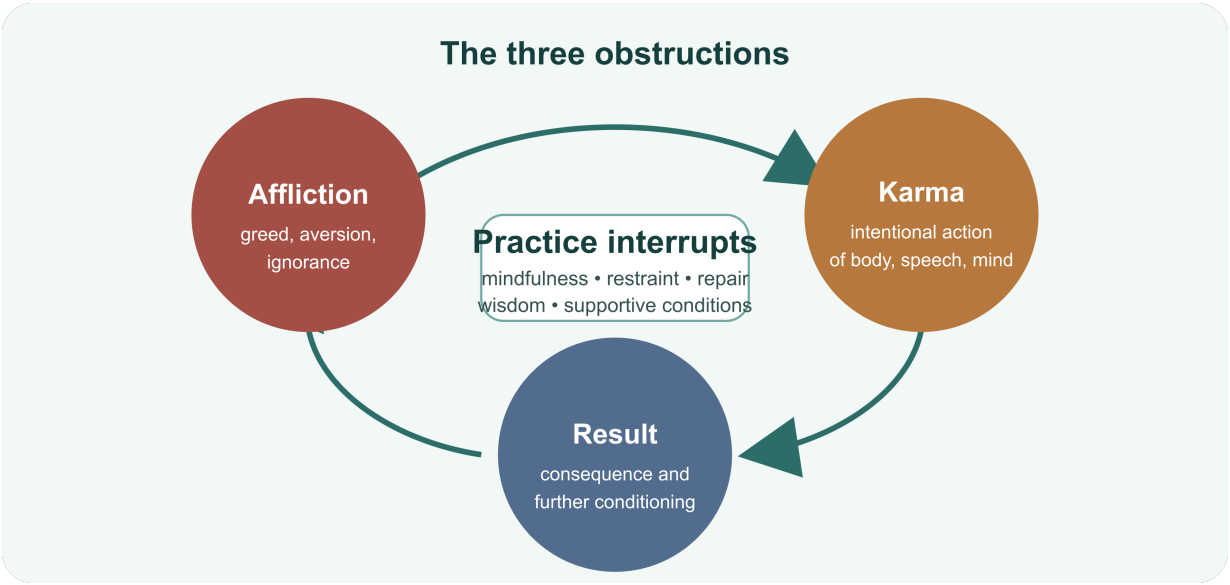
Source pages 23 to 24

What is happening?

The liturgy organises an immense range of wrongdoing into three connected obstructions: afflictions, karma and painful results.

Why is it done?

This turns a catalogue of faults into a diagnosis. If a practitioner sees only the painful result, the inner cause may continue. If they analyse affliction but ignore conduct, insight remains abstract.



What does it mean?

- An affliction disturbs clear awareness.
- Karma is the intentional action it conditions.
- A result is the consequence and further conditioning that follow.

Each can feed the next. The cycle can also be interrupted at every point through mindfulness, restraint, repair, wisdom and supportive conditions.

10. The seven kinds of mind

Source pages 24 to 31

What is happening?

The assembly cultivates seven attitudes before the detailed confession.

Attitude	Practical meaning
Remorse and shame	Admit that the action fell below one's ethical capacity.
Fear	Take consequences seriously instead of assuming they can be avoided.
Dispassion	See that compulsive pleasure and identity cannot provide lasting security.
Bodhi mind	Make reform part of awakening for all beings.
Equality of friend and foe	Refuse to limit compassion to people one likes.
Gratitude to the Buddha	Repay the teaching by practising and sharing it.
Emptiness of transgression	Take responsibility without fixing anyone as permanently corrupt.

Why is it done?

Repentance can fail through denial, panic, self-hatred, resentment or empty performance. The seven minds create a balance of urgency, compassion and wisdom.

Difficult body imagery

The list of body parts and the nine openings is an ancient contemplation of the body as physical, changing and not fit for idealised attachment. It is not a statement that bodies are morally dirty or that bodily care is wrong.

“Friends and foes as equal”

Equality means equal concern for awakening and freedom from suffering. It does not require trusting an unsafe person, abandoning boundaries or pretending that harmful conduct is acceptable.

“Transgressions are empty”

The text says transgressions arise and cease through conditions. This is not an escape from accountability. It explains why accountability can lead to change.

11. Repentance for the obstruction of afflictions

Source pages 32 to 42

What is happening?

The first of the three obstructions becomes the focus. The text begins with greed, anger and ignorance, then expands into a long sequence of numbered lists.

Why is it done?

The sheer range prevents a practitioner from reducing wrongdoing to a few obvious acts. Affliction includes views, habits, doubts, emotional reactions and subtle attachments.

How to read the numbered lists

Treat them as a map of comprehensiveness, not a memory test. A few groups deserve immediate recognition:

- three poisons: greed, hatred and ignorance;
- five coverings: sense desire, ill will, dullness, restlessness and doubt;
- six senses: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind;
- eight sufferings: birth, ageing, illness, death, separation from what is loved, meeting what is disliked, not getting what is wanted and distress connected with clinging to the five aggregates;
- ten afflictions: a scholastic list of primary disturbed states and wrong views;
- eighteen realms: six faculties, six objects and six consciousnesses;
- 108 afflictions: a comprehensive symbolic count of the many ways a mind becomes troubled.

The glossary explains every named group at the level the source supports. It marks lists whose exact members vary or are not supplied.

From confession to vows

The numerical confession is answered by positive aspirations: wisdom, faith, the six perfections, the factors of awakening and the bodhisattva grounds. This structure matters. The practitioner does not merely remove a fault but develops a capacity that makes recurrence less likely.

12. Rectifying the past and cultivating the future

Source pages 43 to 50

What is happening?

The text explains repentance directly: correct the past, cultivate the future, end harmful patterns and give rise to virtues. It asks the practitioner to make the body dignified, the mind reverent and the practice sincere.

Why is it done?

The warning against hidden conduct targets the belief that an unseen act does not matter. Buddhist ethics focuses on what conduct does to the mind and to beings, not only on whether a human authority discovers it.

King Yama and the wardens of hell

The courtroom scene dramatizes unavoidable accountability. Enemies testify about violence and theft; the offender cannot transfer the consequence to family or wealth.

Traditionally, Yama is a ruler or judge connected with the realms of the dead. He is not an all-powerful creator and Buddhist hell is not eternal. Some readers also understand the scene as a psychological image of actions returning through memory, habit, fear and damaged relationships.

The four elements, five aggregates and six senses

The text compares the four elements to snakes, the five aggregates to bandits and the six senses to an empty formation. These are warnings against clinging. They do not teach hatred of the body or the senses.

The positive conclusion is the Noble Eightfold Path: right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness and concentration.

13. Seven Buddhas mantra and exiting repentance

Source pages 51 to 54

What is happening?

The assembly chants the Seven Buddhas Offence-Extinguishing Mantra, recalls the cleansing spring, announces completion of the first scroll and dedicates the merit.

Why is it done?

The mantra seals the confession in a sacred sound formula. The exit prayer prevents an abrupt return to ordinary activity and directs the result towards a wider field.

What does it mean?

The source provides a Sanskrit-derived recitation rather than a prose translation. Its liturgical function is purification. The following verse gives its practical interpretation: the water of samādhi cleanses old enmity, then compassion for oneself becomes compassion for others.

Dedication includes Dharma protectors, spirits, living relatives, ancestors, friends, enemies and all beings. The aspiration to the Pure Land gives this shared benefit a direction towards awakening.

14. Noon Offering Before the Buddhas

Source pages 55 to 58

What is happening?

The assembly invokes the Triple Gem, major Buddhas and bodhisattvas, then chants formulas for transforming food, sweet dew and universal offering.

Why is it done?

Food, one of life's basic supports, becomes a practice of gratitude and impartial generosity. The offering is imagined as reaching Buddhas, sages and all beings in the six realms.

What does it mean?

“Transformation” and “sweet dew” express abundance and relief. The physical portion may be limited, but the vow to nourish and include beings is not.

Beginner notes

- Vulture Peak is the site near ancient Rājagṛha associated with important Mahāyāna teachings, especially the Lotus Sūtra.
- Medicine Master Buddha represents healing and conditions supportive of practice.
- Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas are guardians of Buddhist monasteries and practice places.
- Dhyāna bliss is the joy and ease associated with meditative collectedness.

15. Memorial Altar Dedication

Source pages 59 to 64

What is happening?

The service invokes Amitābha, chants the Heart Sūtra, recites the Rebirth in the Pure Land Dhāraṇī, repeats offering formulas and makes a final dedication.

Why is it done?

The memorial rite joins compassion for the deceased with wisdom about emptiness. Grief is not denied. It is held within a practice that refuses to cling to a fixed self while aspiring towards favourable conditions for awakening.

What does the Heart Sūtra mean here?

Avalokiteśvara sees that the five aggregates are empty of independent essence and crosses beyond suffering. The sūtra then removes every possible object of clinging, even Buddhist teachings and attainment. Its mantra points beyond ordinary conceptual grasping.

This does not say that people or grief are unreal. It says they arise through conditions and cannot be possessed as permanent, separate things.

Why Amitābha?

Amitābha's vows and Pure Land provide a focus for remembrance, trust and aspiration. “Guide and Receiver of the West” expresses the hope that beings will be welcomed into conditions where practice continues without regression.

The closing synthesis

The final wish names Chan, Pure Land, precepts and the patience of equality. It is a compact picture of integrated East Asian Mahāyāna practice:

- Chan steadies and examines the mind;
- Pure Land directs recollection and aspiration;
- precepts guide conduct;
- equality extends patience and compassion without discrimination.

A practical way to carry the text into daily life

After reading a section, use four short questions:

1 What happened? Name the action without disguise.
2 What fed it? Notice craving, aversion, ignorance and surrounding conditions.
3 What can be repaired? Apologise, restore, protect or seek help where appropriate.
4 What will replace it? Make a specific vow and build conditions that support it.

Then dedicate any benefit beyond yourself. This is the ethical movement at the heart of Scroll One.



References

Sources and editorial limits

Links were checked on 22 August 2026. The guide paraphrases its copyrighted source and uses short labels only where necessary for explanation.

Source liturgy

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- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Scroll Two. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Two guide and page map.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Scroll Three. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Three guide, memorial rites and final prayer.

The PDFs credit Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong as translators, editors and graphic designers. They state that reproduction requires the publisher's permission except for fair use. The original PDFs are therefore not included in this repository.

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Artwork records

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Editorial limits

- Sanskrit names and terms are normalised only where the identification is secure. The source spelling remains the reference for chanting.
- English pronunciation cues are approximations, not International Phonetic Alphabet transcriptions.
- Vietnamese names are a recognition aid only. Tone and regional pronunciation should be learned from a Vietnamese speaker or temple.
- Literal and psychological interpretations of cosmological realms are both identified as recognised approaches. The guide does not claim that all Buddhist traditions interpret them in the same way.
- The traditional Wuda narrative is explained respectfully and distinguished from historical verification.

May the benefit of this work support understanding, compassionate reform and the awakening of all beings.

For further Buddhist terminology

www.fgsitc.org/glossary/